Several months later, her office sent a questionnaire to cultural institutions, asking whether they performed in the Galilee and the Negev—historically underdeveloped regions of the country, referred to in Hebrew as "the periphery"—and in Jewish settlements in the West Bank. She threatened to slash their funding by one-third if they did not. Israeli artists already have an incentive to tour the country: their annual payments from the culture ministry are based on the number of performances they put on. Yet much of the country's culture is still concentrated in the major cities along the coastal plain, and in Jerusalem. Regev's effort might have seemed laudable, were it not for one additional provision she tacked on, which revealed her ideological motives: artists who performed in the West Bank stood to receive a small bonus.

Regev, the daughter of Moroccan immigrants, draws much of her appeal from ethnic resentment. She often describes herself as "Miri Regev from Kiryat Gat," a largely Mizrahi town in the south. After she was named culture minister, she gleefully denounced European culture. "I never read Chekhov," she told an interviewer from *Israel HaYom* in 2015. "I listened to Jo Amar [a Moroccan-Israeli singer] and Sephardic songs, and I'm no less cultured than all the consumers of Western culture."[12]

Amulets and idols

Culture remains one of the major gaps between Ashkenazi and Mizrahi Jews. A 2012 analysis by a Mizrahi activist group found, for example, that groups teaching Western styles of dance receive more than 95 per cent of the state funding allocated for dance programs. The orchestras in Tel Aviv and Haifa, whose programs emphasize European classical music, receive millions of shekels each year; an orchestra that performs ancient Middle Eastern music characteristic of the *mizrahim* receives about 70,000 shekels. "People on the periphery don't get money for promoting or creating their own cultural events, on the basis of their own cultural heritage," said Yossi Dahan, a professor and analyst who writes frequently about inequality in Israel.

Some of this can be explained by simple demographics: big cities have larger audiences. But the Ashkenazi left has not done much to endear itself to its critics. For many Israelis, the most memorable moment of Labor's pre-election rally in 2015 was not the ailing Meir Dagan's denunciation of